



THE LITERARY SCIENTIST

A Multi-Disciplinary Journal for Literature and Science

ISSN:3048-7366(Online)

<https://theliteraryscientist.org/>

Volume 1
Issue 2
09.02.2025

Paper Title:

Breaking Barriers with Laughter in “Badhaai Do”

Author:

Pallabi Gharami

Pallabi Gharami is a dedicated academic specializing in English language, literature, and communication. A postgraduate in English, she currently serves as an Assistant Professor at Swami Vivekananda Institute of Science and Technology, where she focuses on fostering critical thinking, effective communication, and professional skills among students. Her research interests include gender studies, queer theories, and film studies, reflecting a keen engagement with contemporary cultural and theoretical discourses.

The Literary Scientist (TLS) A Multi-Disciplinary Journal for Literature and Science follows an Open Access Policy for copyright and licensing. If you are using or reproducing content from this platform, you need to appropriately cite the author(s) and the Journal name

Breaking Barriers with Laughter in “Badhaai Do”

_____ Pallabi Gharami

Abstract

"Badhaai Do" is a sensitive comedy - drama about the Indian cultural landscape and identity in the queer spectrum, challenging questions of societal norms and personal liberation. The plot follows the unusual union of Shardul (Rajkummar Rao) and Sumi (Bhumi Pednekar), who belong to the LGBTQ+ community but marry each other as a matter of societal compromise. The movie balances humor with sensitivity, as it criticizes the rigid constructs of heteronormativity and makes sure to remind them of self-acceptance and authenticity. Layered performances, insightful writing, and engaging narration in the film "Badhaai Do" encourage meaningful conversations about individuality and inclusion. Critical evaluation of the film leads to a better understanding of powerful direction, extraordinary cinematography, and a complex script; though pacing issues occasionally prevent the movie's momentum. Generally speaking, the film resonates like a bold narration and finds application in contemporary times.

Title of the Film: “Badhaai Do”

Original Language and Year of Release: Hindi, 2022

Director: Harshavardhan Kulkarni

Production Details: Junglee Pictures, India

Duration: 147 minutes

Genre: Comedy-Drama

1. Overview of the Film:

"Badhaai Do," (2022) set in India, captures the cultural and social struggles of queer individuals living in the shadow of heteronormative norms. Released in the post-pandemic environment, it captures an increasing discourse on LGBTQ+ rights, echoing a cultural shift after the decriminalization of Section 377 in India.

2. Aims of the Review:

This film review aims to analyze the aesthetic and thematic elements of the film, trying to understand how it portrays queer issues sensitively while incorporating comedy. It also gauges the implications of the film in terms of society and culture within contemporary Indian cinema.

3. Plot Synopsis

A closeted gay policeman, Shardul Thakur, and a lesbian physical education teacher, Suman Singh, get into a lavender marriage just to please their families while continuing to lead lives on their terms. However, the plot further develops as a mixture of humor and poignancy as Shardul and Suman move on with this dual life, trying to adjust to the familial expectations, and exploring each other's personal romantic lives as well.

4. Thematic Analysis

This mainstream Hindi film portrays the lives of queer people within a conservative Indian society, dealing with issues of self-acceptance, personal happiness, and "found families." The film raises issues of tension between societal, familial expectations and individual desires. It gives a poignant critique of rigid heteronormativity. Addressing LGBTQ+ issues within an Indian cultural setting challenges prevalent stigmas, intrusive families and calls for normalizing diverse sexual identities. It also reflects the ongoing cultural shift between tradition and modernity, underlining the evolving narrative of acceptance and equality in contemporary India.

5. Cinematic Techniques

5.1. Direction:

Harshavardhan Kulkarni's light, yet impactful direction has blended humor with emotions well. That stands out as his brilliant ability to express complex human relationships.

5.2. Cinematography:

Swapnil Sonawane's work imbues vibrancy on screen by juxtaposing hopeful, bright visuals with intimate close-up shots that point to emotional weight.

5.3. Editing:

The pacing falters at times, especially in the second half, but transitions and continuity overall support the rhythm of the narrative.

5.4. Sound Design:

Amit Trivedi's score complements the film's tone, with songs and background music that add layers to both comedic and emotional moments. Diegetic sounds, such as familial chatter, ground the narrative in reality.

5.5. Performances:

Rajkummar Rao performs grippingly as a man who balances his inner voice to the societal expectations. Bhumi Pednekar as Sumi adds drama, depth and relatability to her character. Sheeba Chadha is noticeable as one of the highlighted supporting characters of the film. Gulshan Devaiah's cameo is a welcome surprise.

6. Critical Evaluation

The biggest strength of the film is the sensitive and perceptive treatment of LGBTQ+ issues. The script catches our attention for its honest portrayal of modern dilemmas of society, which makes the narrative very relatable and impactful. Its appeal is also facilitated by the strong

performances of lead actors Rajkummar Rao and Bhumi Pednekar, coupled with a fantastic supporting cast.

However, the movie is not without its flaws. The runtime at times feels unnecessarily stretched, with certain subplots dragging on and affecting the overall pace. Furthermore, while the resolution is optimistic and uplifting, it leans toward idealism, which may oversimplify the complexity of the themes it seeks to address.

7. Cultural and Societal Impact

"Badhaai Do" can be called a landmark film that normalizes queer narratives within the landscape of Indian mainstream cinema. It is exceptional and humorous, showing the struggles and triumphs of LGBTQ+ individuals, thereby fostering a deeper understanding and empathy for their lived experiences. For modern audiences, it underlines the critical need for inclusivity while championing the celebration of individuality and diversity in a society undergoing cultural transformation.

8. Conclusion

"Badhaai Do" is a benchmark film in Indian cinema, presenting a bold and sensitive portrayal of LGBTQ+ issues. Though it has its shortcomings, the film's humor, performances, and social commentary make it an impactful film that challenges conventions and encourages dialogue. It confirms its place as a milestone in Bollywood's evolving narrative landscape.

References

Times of India (Movie Review): Times of India. (2022, February 11). Badhaai Do movie review: A hilarious but touching take on a lavender marriage. The Times of India.

<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/entertainment/hindi/movie-reviews/badhaai-do/movie-review/89476782.cms>

YouTube Playlist: YouTube. (n.d.). Badhaai Do [Playlist]. YouTube Music.

https://music.youtube.com/playlist?list=OLAK5uy_k-IzY08Via0oyjL_PN9TWkT7zEgRVFczQ

The Hindu (Movies): The Hindu. (n.d.). Entertainment | Movies. The Hindu.

<https://www.thehindu.com/entertainment/movies/>

Scroll.in (Movie Review): Scroll.in. (2022, February 11). Badhaai Do review: A lavender marriage struggles through the sludge. Scroll.in. <https://scroll.in/reel/1016857/badhaai-do-review-a-lavender-marriage-struggles-through-the-sludge>